



The Gospel of John

The Word Became Flesh — The Gospel of Faith and Love

That you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God

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Introduction

Welcome to a journey through the deepest and sweetest of the New Testament Gospels. The Gospel of John is not merely a narrative of the events of Christ's life; it is an open invitation to every reader: to know Christ personally, to believe in Him, and to find life in Him. John the Beloved wrote it in his old age, after living with Christ for three years, leaning on His breast, standing beneath His cross, and seeing Him risen from the dead. His Gospel is thus the fruit of a lifetime of love and contemplation.

This book is not an academic commentary, but a simplified study for every one of us: we will walk together, chapter by chapter, through the Gospel of John — understanding what happened, discovering what it means for us today, and learning how to live it in our homes, our churches, and our daily lives. In each chapter you will find a simple explanation, a practical reflection, and a verse to keep in your heart.

John himself told us why he wrote his Gospel: "But these are written, that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God; and that believing ye might have life through his name" (John 20:31). This is also the purpose of the book in your hands: that your faith may grow, and that your life may be filled with the love that filled John's heart. Read slowly, pray as you read, and ask the Holy Spirit to open your eyes as He opened the eyes of the beloved disciple.

Before you begin reading, one last piece of advice from a loving heart: do not read this book as a school assignment, but as love letters. John did not write for cold minds, but for thirsty hearts. Every chapter holds a personal invitation to you: come and see; taste and see how good the Lord is. And if in some chapter you find a word that touches your heart, pause at it and pray with it — perhaps it is the very word God prepared for you on this particular day.

Why the Gospel of John in particular? Because since the earliest ages the Church has seen in it the spiritual Gospel that reveals the divinity of Christ with unmatched clarity. While Matthew presents Christ the King, Mark Christ the Servant, and Luke Christ the perfect Man, John presents Christ the God:

the eternal Word who became flesh. That is why the Gospel of John is read in the Coptic Church in many fasts and feasts, and why its verses are engraved on believers' hearts across the generations.

As you read, you will notice that John builds his Gospel around seven signs — seven carefully chosen miracles — and seven "I am" sayings. Every sign testifies to Christ, and every saying reveals an aspect of His person. And at the end of the journey you will find yourself facing the question Christ put to His disciples: "But whom say ye that I am?" — and the only right answer is Thomas's: "My Lord and my God."

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Chapter 1

Who Is John? What Makes His Gospel Unique?

Who was John? He was a simple young man from Galilee, a fisherman working with his father Zebedee and his brother James on the Sea of Galilee. He was no scholar or philosopher, but a working man who knew nets, boats, and the sea. Then one day Jesus passed by the shore and called him, and he left his nets and followed Him at once. Thus began the greatest friendship in history: the friendship of a simple man with the Son of God.

He soon became one of three disciples closest to Christ, along with Peter and James. He was with Him on the Mount of Transfiguration when he saw Christ's glory, and with Him in the Garden of Gethsemane on the night of the Passion; he was the only one of the apostles who stood beneath the cross to the very end. There, from the cross, Christ entrusted to him His most precious treasure on earth: His mother, the Virgin Mary. John took her into his home and cared for her. No wonder the whole Church calls him "the beloved disciple" — he is the one who leaned on Christ's breast at the Last Supper and heard His heartbeat up close.

After Christ's resurrection and ascension, John served the Church for many long years, finally settling in the city of Ephesus, where he lived to an advanced old age. According to the Church's tradition, he wrote his Gospel there near the end of the first century, years after the first three Gospels had been written. That is why his Gospel is different: he did not repeat what the others had written, but completed the picture from a deeper angle — the angle of theology and love.

What makes the Gospel of John distinctive? The first thing that strikes you is that John does not begin with Christ's birth in Bethlehem, but from eternity: "In the beginning was the Word." He lifts our gaze at once to heaven before bringing us down to earth. That is why the Church symbolized him with the eagle: like an eagle he soars high in the sky of divinity and sees what the others did not see — that Jesus of Nazareth is God manifest in the flesh.

The second distinctive mark is his focus on "signs" rather than "miracles." John chose only seven signs from among Christ's many miracles, and each one points to a deeper truth: turning water into wine points to the joy of the new covenant; feeding the multitudes points to Christ the Bread of Life; raising Lazarus points to Him who is the Resurrection and the Life Himself. With him, a miracle is not a display of power, but a window through which we see who Christ is.

The third is the seven "I am" sayings: I am the Bread of Life; I am the Light of the World; I am the Door; I am the Good Shepherd; I am the Resurrection and the Life; I am the Way, the Truth, and the Life; I am the True Vine. In each saying Christ reveals an aspect of His person and His relationship with us. Note that the expression "I am" in Greek recalls the name God revealed to Moses: "I AM THAT I AM" — the One who is. In these sayings, Christ plainly declares His divinity.

But the most beautiful thing about the Gospel is its stated purpose: "these are written, that ye might believe." John does not write to impress you with his style, but to lead you into living faith. For him, faith is not information to memorize, but a relationship of trust and love with a living person. That is why you will find the word "believe" repeated dozens of times in the Gospel, while the noun "faith" as an abstract concept appears only rarely. Faith is a living act: to come to Christ, to receive Him, to abide in Him.

How can you benefit from this study? Read each chapter of the Gospel itself first if you can, then read the explanation here. Do not rush; the Gospel of John is like a deep well — the further down you go, the sweeter the water you find. Memorize one verse from each chapter and repeat it through your day. And always ask yourself two questions: What does this chapter teach me about Christ? And what does it ask me to change in my life? In this simple way, the Gospel will turn from a book you read into a life you live.

Chapter 2

The Word Became Flesh (John 1)

The Word became flesh. John opens his Gospel with the greatest introduction ever written in the history of literature: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God." The word "beginning" here takes us back to the first verse of the Bible: "In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth." John is telling us: before anything existed, Christ already was. He is not a creature whose existence began in Bethlehem; He is eternal, existing before all ages.

And who is "the Word"? In Greek, "Logos," which means word, thought, and wisdom together. Just as your word expresses your inner thought and reveals what is in your heart, so Christ is the Word of God by whom God expressed Himself to mankind. The invisible God became visible in Christ; whoever wants to know God, let him look at Jesus. That is why John says, "And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us." This is the very heart of Christianity: God did not remain far away in His heaven, but came down to us and became man like us — eating, drinking, growing weary, weeping — to lift us up into His fellowship.

John then introduces the figure of John the Baptist, wisely clarifying: "He was not that Light, but was sent to bear witness of that Light." The Baptist was a great prophet, and crowds gathered around him, until some thought he was the Christ. But John the Evangelist puts each one in his place: the Baptist is merely a witness pointing his finger to Christ, like a lamp lighting the way before the sun. This is a lesson for us all: the greatest service we can render is not to make people see us, but to direct them to Christ.

Then comes one of the sweetest verses in the Gospel: "But as many as received him, to them gave he power to become the sons of God." Notice it does not say "all who heard of Him" or "all who admired Him," but "as many as received him." Faith is a personal receiving: opening your heart to Christ and welcoming Him as Lord and Savior. And the reward is astounding: you become a child of God! Not by physical birth nor by the will of man, but by a spiritual

birth from God Himself.

The first chapter closes with Christ's first encounters with His disciples — lessons in simple evangelism. Andrew heard the Baptist say, "Behold the Lamb of God," and followed Jesus; and the first thing he did was go to his brother Simon Peter and say to him, "We have found the Messiah." Philip called Nathanael, who objected, "Can there any good thing come out of Nazareth?" Philip answered with two words that changed history: "Come and see." He did not argue with him or lecture him; he invited him to a personal encounter. And so it is with all true evangelism: do not try to convince people with words — lead them to Christ Himself, and He will take care of the rest.

How do we live this chapter? First: lift up your eyes. Many see Christ as merely a good teacher or a great prophet, but John invites you to see Him as He is: God manifest in the flesh. Pray to Him as God, and lean on Him as a friend. Second: be a witness like the Baptist. Do not try to be the light yourself; direct those around you to the true Light by your words and your conduct. Third: receive Christ anew every day. Faith is not a decision you made once in the past, but a renewed receiving every morning: "Lord, come into my life today, and guide my steps."

There is one more truth in this chapter worth contemplating: John says of Christ that He was "full of grace and truth." Grace alone without truth becomes permissiveness, and truth alone without grace becomes harshness. But Christ combined them perfectly: grace that receives the sinner, and truth that never compromises with sin. When we deal with people, would that we learned this balance from Him: to love without limits, and to hold to the truth without compromise.

Finally, reflect on the first title the Baptist gave Christ: "Behold the Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world." From the very first chapter, John proclaims the theme of redemption: Christ came as a Lamb to be slain for our sins, as the Passover lamb was in the Old Testament. The whole Gospel moves toward the cross, and the cross is not a defeat but a sacrifice of love that takes away the sin of the world — your sin too. Receive Him today as the redeeming Lamb, and tomorrow you will find Him the glorified King.

Chapter 3

Nicodemus: Born from Above (John 3)

Nicodemus: born from above. Nicodemus was a respectable man by every measure: a member of the Jewish council, a devout Pharisee, and a teacher of the Law known to all. But his heart was troubled. He had seen Christ's signs and heard His teaching, and realized this Man was no ordinary man. Yet he feared his colleagues, so he came to Jesus by night, in secret. How many of us are like Nicodemus! We admire Christ in our hearts, but we are ashamed to declare our faith before people.

Nicodemus opened with a compliment: "Rabbi, we know that thou art a teacher come from God." But Jesus went past the compliment straight to the heart of the matter: "Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God." Imagine the man's astonishment! He who had spent his life keeping the Law and applying it is told by Christ: all of this is not enough; you need a completely new beginning — a second birth.

Nicodemus asked in amazement, "How can a man be born when he is old? can he enter the second time into his mother's womb, and be born?" So Christ explained that the birth is not physical but spiritual: "Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God." The water points to baptism, and the Spirit points to the work of the Holy Spirit renewing the heart from within. Man in his fallen nature cannot fix himself, no matter how hard he tries; he needs a new creation that God works in him. And just as a child does not birth himself but is born, so spiritual birth is a gift from God received by faith.

Then we come to the most famous verse in all the Bible: "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life" (John 3:16). Pause at every word: "so loved" — a love without limits or conditions. "The world" — not the righteous only, but the whole world with its sins and weaknesses, and you are one of this world. "He gave his only begotten Son" — true love proves itself by giving, and God gave His most precious. "That whosoever believeth in him

should not perish" — salvation is for all without exception, and the condition is one and simple: to believe. "But have everlasting life" — not merely escape from perishing, but a new, eternal life that begins now and continues in heaven.

Christ continues: "For God sent not his Son into the world to condemn the world; but that the world through him might be saved." Christ did not come to judge us while we are sinners, but to save us while we are sinners. The true condemnation is for man to reject the light and choose darkness. The problem is not that God is harsh, but that man flees from the light because his deeds are evil.

The end of Nicodemus's story is delightful: this man who came by night in fear is later found defending Christ openly before the council (John 7), and in the end he comes with Joseph of Arimathea to bury Christ's body himself (John 19). The faith that began as a whisper in the night grew into open, courageous testimony. That is how Christ works in hearts: He begins with a fearful night visit and ends with a radiant life.

How do we live this chapter? Ask yourself honestly: have you truly been born from above, or is your Christianity merely habits and traditions? The new birth means a new heart that loves God and hates sin — not mere outward behavior. And if, like Nicodemus, you hide your faith for fear of people, remember that Christ deserves to be proclaimed by day, not by night. Begin with a small step: pray aloud before your family, carry your Bible without shame, or defend the truth when Christ is maligned. The light within you is stronger than all the darkness around you.

Chapter 4

The Samaritan Woman: Living Water (John 4)

The Samaritan woman: living water. In chapter three a devout man came by night; in chapter four a sinful woman comes by day. John places the two stories side by side to tell us: Christ is for all. To Him there is no difference between the respectable Pharisee and the marginalized woman; both need salvation, and both find it in Him.

The Jews had no dealings with the Samaritans, and men did not speak with strange women on the road; and this woman in particular had a bad reputation in her village — she came to draw water at the hot noontime hour to avoid the other women's glances. But Jesus deliberately passed through Samaria and sat by the well waiting for her. It was no coincidence, but a divine appointment. How many times has God arranged such "coincidences" in our lives to meet us in them!

The conversation began with a simple request: "Give me to drink." The woman was surprised: "How is it that thou, being a Jew, askest drink of me, which am a woman of Samaria?" Jesus answered her, "If thou knewest the gift of God, and who it is that saith to thee, Give me to drink; thou wouldest have asked of him, and he would have given thee living water." Then He explained the difference: whoever drinks of the well's water will thirst again, but "whosoever drinketh of the water that I shall give him shall never thirst; but the water that I shall give him shall be in him a well of water springing up into everlasting life." The well's water symbolizes everything people seek to quench their hearts' thirst: money, fame, relationships, pleasures. All of them satisfy for a moment, then the thirst returns fiercer. But Christ gives a lasting inward satisfaction — a spring that never runs dry.

Then Christ unveiled her life to her: she had had five husbands, and the one she was with now was not her husband. He did not do this to expose her, but to show her that He knows everything about her and still loves her and seeks her. Here the woman shifted from defense to confession, and asked Him about true worship: where should God be worshiped? Christ gave her the greatest

definition of worship: "God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth." True worship is not a place or mere outward ritual, but a broken heart meeting God in spirit, and sincere worship without hypocrisy.

Then He made to her the greatest revelation: "I that speak unto thee am he" — I am the awaited Messiah. Notice to whom Christ first declared Himself with such clarity: not to the high priest or the king, but to a sinful Samaritan woman at a well! This is the message of the Gospel: grace reaches the farthest and the lowest.

And the result is astonishing: the woman left her waterpot — the symbol of her old life and earthly needs — and went into the city proclaiming, "Come, see a man, which told me all things that ever I did: is not this the Christ?" The woman who had been ashamed to meet people became an evangelist drawing a whole city! And many Samaritans believed, and said to her, "Now we believe, not because of thy saying: for we have heard him ourselves, and know that this is indeed the Christ, the Saviour of the world."

How do we live this chapter? First: despise no one and despair of no one. If Christ sat with the Samaritan woman, spoke with her, and revealed Himself to her, then no one is beyond His grace — beginning with you. Second: search out your true thirst. What do you think will satisfy you? A position? Money? A relationship? Try bringing that thirst to Christ, and you will find the living water. Third: worship in spirit and in truth. Do not settle for attending the Liturgy bodily while your heart is absent; enter God's presence with a sincere heart, sing from your depths, and pray honestly. Fourth: leave your waterpot and go proclaim. Every true believer automatically becomes a witness; tell one person this week what Christ has done with you.

Notice how Christ dealt with her ignorance and led her step by step: He began with the physical water she understood, then led her to the spiritual water, then to her personal life, then to worship, then revealed Himself to her. This is how God deals with us: He does not demand perfection at once, but leads us step by step, bearing with us patiently until we mature. So do not despair at the slowness of your spiritual growth; what matters is that you are walking

with Him on the way, and He will complete the work He began in you.

Chapter 5

The Living Bread from Heaven (John 6)

The living bread from heaven. Great crowds came to Jesus — about five thousand men, besides women and children — because they saw His signs. When evening came and hunger set in, Philip asked, "Whence shall we buy bread, that these may eat?" The sum required was staggering. But a small boy offered what he had: five barley loaves and two fish. You may think what you own is small and insignificant, but Christ takes the little you offer in love and works wonders with it. He took the loaves, gave thanks, and distributed; all ate and were filled, and they gathered the fragments: twelve baskets full! God does not merely meet the need — He overflows.

But the crowds misunderstood the sign. They wanted to seize Him and make Him an earthly king who would feed them and free them from the Romans. So Jesus withdrew to the mountain alone. In the morning they followed Him, and He exposed the truth of their motives: "Ye seek me, not because ye saw the miracles, but because ye did eat of the loaves, and were filled." Then He directed them to what matters: "Labour not for the meat which perisheth, but for that meat which endureth unto everlasting life." How many of us seek Christ only for earthly blessings — health, money, success — forgetting the true bread!

Here Christ preached His great sermon on the Bread of Life: "I am the bread of life: he that cometh to me shall never hunger; and he that believeth on me shall never thirst." As bread is essential to the body's life, so Christ is essential to the soul's life. Then He went deeper: "I am the living bread which came down from heaven: if any man eat of this bread, he shall live for ever: and the bread that I will give is my flesh, which I will give for the life of the world."

The Jews murmured at this saying, so Christ affirmed it forcefully: "Verily, verily, I say unto you, Except ye eat the flesh of the Son of man, and drink his blood, ye have no life in you. Whoso eateth my flesh, and drinketh my blood, hath eternal life; and I will raise him up at the last day." Our Coptic Orthodox Church believes these words are fulfilled literally in the mystery of Holy

Communion: the bread and wine are transformed by the Holy Spirit into the true Body and Blood of the Lord, and whoever partakes of them worthily abides in Christ and Christ in him. That is why we prepare for Communion with repentance, confession, and fasting, and partake with reverence and faith.

But many of the disciples found the saying hard, and went back and walked no more with Him. So Jesus turned to the Twelve and asked them, "Will ye also go away?" Peter answered with immortal words: "Lord, to whom shall we go? thou hast the words of eternal life." This is the true test of faith: when the saying is hard and we do not understand everything, do we stay with Christ trusting in Him, or leave Him? Mature faith says with Peter: I do not understand everything, but I know You — to whom else shall I go?

How do we live this chapter? First: offer what you have, however small. That boy was not ashamed of his five loaves, and with them thousands were fed. Your talent, your time, your little money — place them in Christ's hands and you will be amazed. Second: examine your motives. Do you follow Christ for His gifts or for Himself? Seek His face before His hand. Third: hold fast to the mystery of Communion. Do not let it become a routine habit; prepare well, approach with reverence, and remember that you are united with Christ Himself. Fourth: when something in the faith is hard for you to understand, do not run away — stand firm and say with Peter, "Lord, to whom shall we go? thou hast the words of eternal life."

Notice also the lesson of thanksgiving: before Christ multiplied the bread, He "took the loaves; and when he had given thanks." Thanksgiving always precedes blessing. Many wait for abundance before they give thanks, but faith gives thanks for the little, and the much follows. Begin your day with thanks for what you have — your health, your home, your family — and you will see God's hand multiplying the little in your life as He multiplied the boy's loaves.

Chapter 6

The Light of the World and the Good Shepherd (John 8-10)

The light of the world and the Good Shepherd. During the Feast of Tabernacles, while Jesus was teaching in the temple, the scribes and Pharisees brought to Him a woman caught in adultery, set her in the midst, and said to Him, "Master, this woman was taken in adultery, in the very act. Now Moses in the law commanded us, that such should be stoned: but what sayest thou?" It was a well-laid trap: if He said, stone her, He would contradict His teaching on mercy; if He said, let her go, He would break the law of Moses and they would accuse Him.

But Jesus stooped down and with His finger wrote on the ground. When they kept pressing Him with the question, He stood up and spoke His immortal word: "He that is without sin among you, let him first cast a stone at her." Then He stooped down again and wrote on the ground. So they went out one by one, beginning with the elders, down to the last, for their consciences convicted them. Jesus was left alone, and the woman standing in the midst. He said to her, "Woman, where are those thine accusers? hath no man condemned thee?" She said, "No man, Lord." And Jesus said to her, "Neither do I condemn thee: go, and sin no more."

Contemplate Christ's wisdom and mercy: He did not justify the sin — He told her plainly, "go, and sin no more" — but He did not condemn the sinner; He gave her a new chance. This is how He deals with us every day: He knows our sins fully, yet He does not pelt us with stones; He calls us to repentance and opens to us the door of a new beginning. And the lesson for the Pharisees — and for us: before you judge another, look at yourself first. It is easy to see the speck in your brother's eye and ignore the plank in your own.

Then Jesus proclaimed, "I am the light of the world: he that followeth me shall not walk in darkness, but shall have the light of life." This was during the Feast of Tabernacles, when huge candlesticks were lit in the temple recalling the pillar of fire that led the people in the wilderness. Christ was saying: I am

the true Light to which that pillar pointed. Whoever follows Him does not stumble in the darkness of sin, ignorance, and lostness, but walks in the light. And following here is not theoretical knowledge, but practical walking behind Him every day.

In chapter ten, Christ presents Himself in another beloved image: the Good Shepherd. "I am the good shepherd: the good shepherd giveth his life for the sheep." The difference between a shepherd and a hireling is that the hireling flees when the wolf comes because he does not care for the sheep; the true shepherd protects them with his life. And Christ truly laid down His life on the cross for us. Then He adds, "My sheep hear my voice, and I know them, and they follow me: And I give unto them eternal life; and they shall never perish, neither shall any man pluck them out of my hand." What assurances! Christ knows each one of us by name, leads us, keeps us — and no one, neither devil nor circumstance, can snatch us out of His hand.

How do we live this chapter? First: stop throwing stones. Before you condemn a fallen person, remember that Christ said to you also, "Neither do I condemn thee." Be merciful as you were shown mercy. Second: accept forgiveness and begin anew. Whatever your sin, Christ does not condemn you; He calls you: "Go, and sin no more." Rise from your fall now. Third: follow the Light practically. Do not walk in darkness and then complain of lostness; make God's word a lamp for your steps and decisions. Fourth: rest in the Shepherd's hand. When you fear the future or the powers of evil, remember: you are in the hand of Him who laid down His life for you, and no one shall ever snatch you from it.

One last touch we should not miss: John notes that Jesus wrote with His finger on the ground twice. He did not tell us what He wrote, but many of the Fathers saw in it a sign that God is the One who once wrote the Law with His finger on the tablets of stone, and now writes mercy with His finger on the dust of the earth. The Law given on stone is now written in love on hearts. So do not despair if you have broken the commandment; the One who wrote it is the same One who blots it out with His blood.

Chapter 7

The Raising of Lazarus (John 11)

The raising of Lazarus: I am the Resurrection and the Life. In the little village of Bethany, a short distance from Jerusalem, lived a family Jesus loved with a special love: Martha, Mary, and Lazarus. Their home was His refuge when He grew weary of the pressing crowds. One day Lazarus fell gravely ill, and the sisters sent to Jesus saying, "Lord, behold, he whom thou lovest is sick."

Notice they asked for nothing explicitly; they simply laid the matter before Him with a lover's confidence: You love him, and You know what to do.

But Jesus did something strange: He stayed where He was for two more days! Is this not perplexing? The One who loves them delays coming to them? But John reveals the reason: "This sickness is not unto death, but for the glory of God, that the Son of God might be glorified thereby." Sometimes God delays His answer not because He does not care, but because He is preparing a greater glory. Had Christ healed Lazarus of his sickness, it would have been a great miracle; but He wanted to raise him from the dead after four days — a greater sign displaying His authority over death itself.

Jesus arrived to find that Lazarus had already been dead four days. Martha came out to meet Him and said with a lover's reproach, "Lord, if thou hadst been here, my brother had not died." He answered her with the greatest self-revelation: "I am the resurrection, and the life: he that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live: And whosoever liveth and believeth in me shall never die. Believest thou this?" He did not say "I give the resurrection" but "I am the resurrection" — the resurrection is not merely a future event, but a living Person standing before her! Whoever believes in Him possesses eternal life now, and physical death cannot touch his true life.

Then He went to the tomb, and there we see the shortest and deepest verse in the Bible: "Jesus wept." The God of the universe, all-powerful, stood before His friend's tomb and wept. He did not weep from helplessness — He was about to raise him in moments — but He wept sharing human feelings. This verse is a treasure for every grieving heart: our God is not far from our pains; He weeps

with those who weep. When you lose a loved one or pass through distress, remember that Christ shares your tears before He wipes them away.

Then He cried with a loud voice, "Lazarus, come forth!" And the dead man came out, his hands and feet bound with graveclothes and his face wrapped with a napkin. Jesus said to them, "Loose him, and let him go." Notice the details: Christ is the One who raises from the dead, yet He asks the disciples to loose the bindings — the Church has a role in freeing souls from their bonds after Christ raises them. And many of the Jews who saw what He did believed.

But the chief priests and Pharisees, instead of believing, gathered and decided to kill Him! Caiaphas said, "It is expedient for us, that one man should die for the people." And so the raising of Lazarus — Christ's greatest sign — became the direct cause that drove them to the cross. The blazing light blinded the eyes of darkness instead of guiding them.

How do we live this chapter? First: trust God's timing. When He delays with you, do not think He has forgotten you; perhaps He is preparing for you a glory greater than what you asked. Second: bring Him your own "if thou hadst been here." Reproach Him with a lover's honesty as Martha did; He loves honesty more than compliments. Third: hold to hope in the face of death. If you have lost a believing loved one, remember Christ's promise: "he that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live." The parting is temporary; the reunion is eternal. Fourth: let Christ loose your bindings. Are there still bonds from your past? Habits? Memories? Ask Him to set you free, and let your brothers and sisters in the Church help you.

There is a hidden lesson in Christ's two-day delay: sometimes God allows your problem to worsen — the sickness intensifies, the debt piles up, the relationship deteriorates — not to torment you, but because the divine solution is greater when it comes after human despair. Lazarus could have been healed, but he was raised from the dead! So do not judge God's delay as abandonment; perhaps He is preparing for you not merely a healing, but a resurrection.

Chapter 8

The Washing of Feet and the New Commandment (John 13)

The washing of feet and the new commandment. On the night of the Last Supper, hours before the cross, Jesus did something no one expected: He "riseth from supper, and laid aside his garments; and took a towel, and girded himself. After that he poureth water into a bason, and began to wash the disciples' feet, and to wipe them with the towel wherewith he was girded." In those days, washing feet was a slave's work, for people walked barefoot on dusty roads. Imagine: the King of kings, whom they confessed as Teacher and Lord, bending at their feet one by one!

Peter objected, as was his way: "Lord, dost thou wash my feet?" Jesus answered him, "What I do thou knowest not now; but thou shalt know hereafter." When Peter persisted in refusing, Jesus said to him, "If I wash thee not, thou hast no part with me." Peter cried out, "Lord, not my feet only, but also my hands and my head!" Jesus answered that he who has bathed — the renewed believer — needs only the washing of the feet: the daily cleansing from the sins of the road.

When He had finished washing, He asked them, "Know ye what I have done to you?" Then He explained the lesson: "Ye call me Master and Lord: and ye say well; for so I am. If I then, your Lord and Master, have washed your feet; ye also ought to wash one another's feet." Then He laid down the golden rule: "For I have given you an example, that ye should do as I have done to you." Leadership in God's kingdom is not domination or privilege, but service and bending low. The greatest among men is the one who serves most.

Then He gave them the new commandment: "A new commandment I give unto you, That ye love one another; as I have loved you, that ye also love one another. By this shall all men know that ye are my disciples, if ye have love one to another." Note that it is "new" not because love was never mentioned in the Old Testament — "thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself" was said — but because its measure is new: "as I have loved you." And Christ loved us unto

death, the death of the cross. The required love is not tender feelings, but self-giving sacrifice. And He said this love is the mark by which the world knows we are His disciples: not miracles, not theological information, but practical love.

That same night Jesus revealed that one of them would betray Him, and the disciples were troubled. And Judas went out into the night — "and it was night," John comments sorrowfully. While Christ was washing feet and speaking of love, Judas was on his way to sell Him for thirty pieces of silver. What a contrast! Yet Christ washed Judas's feet too, and gave him the morsel with a loving hand to the very end. This is how Christ loves — even those who betray Him.

How do we live this chapter? First: bend low and serve. Look for "foot washing" in your daily life: a tiring task no one thanks you for, a service to someone who cannot repay you, a hidden act of help. This is the true path to greatness. Second: let Christ wash you daily. Do not settle for your baptism in the past; confess your sins continually, and seek daily cleansing in prayer and the mystery of confession. Third: love as He loved you. Ask yourself: do people know I am Christ's disciple by my love? Love is seen in deeds: forgiving one who wronged you, giving generously, a word of encouragement to the sorrowful. Fourth: beware the way of Judas. He was near Christ bodily but far from Him in heart; formal nearness to the Church is useless if the heart is attached to money or sin.

And do not miss the timing of this lesson: Christ washed the feet knowing the cross was hours away. The greatest act of humility came forth on the darkest night. This teaches us that true love does not wait for ideal circumstances; it serves in the hardest times. When you are weighed down with your own cares, look around: perhaps someone needs you to wash his feet — with a word, a visit, a helping hand — and you will discover that serving him has lightened your own burden too.

Chapter 9

The Farewell Discourse 1: The Way, the Truth, and the Life (John 14)

The farewell discourse 1: the Way, the Truth, and the Life. After the Last Supper, before going to Gethsemane and the cross, Jesus sat with His disciples and spoke to them His words of farewell. They were troubled and afraid: their Teacher was speaking of parting, Judas had gone out into the night, and Peter would deny Him. Christ began with the tenderest words: "Let not your heart be troubled: ye believe in God, believe also in me. In my Father's house are many mansions... I go to prepare a place for you. And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again, and receive you unto myself; that where I am, there ye may be also."

Contemplate the beauty of this promise: Christ does not leave us to face the unknown alone; He is going to prepare a place for us in the Father's house. The word "mansions" means lasting dwellings — real homes, not temporary tents. And Christ Himself will come to take us — not angels, not messengers, but He personally. And the goal is not palaces or gold, but fellowship: "that where I am, there ye may be also." Heaven in its essence is not a place, but a Person: to be with Christ forever.

Then He said to them, "And whither I go ye know, and the way ye know." Thomas asked with his characteristic frankness, "Lord, we know not whither thou goest; and how can we know the way?" Jesus answered with the greatest answer: "I am the way, the truth, and the life: no man cometh unto the Father, but by me." Notice He did not say "I point to the way" but "I am the way" itself. The road to God is not a system, a philosophy, or good works, but a living Person: Jesus Christ. He is the full truth that dispels every error, and the true life that satisfies the heart.

Philip asked Him, "Lord, shew us the Father, and it sufficeth us." Jesus answered with a lover's reproach: "Have I been so long time with you, and yet hast thou not known me, Philip? he that hath seen me hath seen the Father." Whoever wants to know how God loves, how He shows mercy, how He forgives

— let him look at Jesus. Everything Christ did on earth is a living revelation of the Father's heart.

Then He promised His disciples two great things: first, that he who believes in Him will do the works that He does, and even greater, because Christ is going to the Father and will work through them by the Holy Spirit. Second, that He will pray the Father to give them "another Comforter" to abide with them forever — the Holy Spirit. The word "Comforter" means the advocate, supporter, and encourager who stands beside you. Christ will not leave us orphans; He will be with us by His Spirit all the days.

He sealed this part with words of peace: "Peace I leave with you, my peace I give unto you: not as the world giveth, give I unto you. Let not your heart be troubled, neither let it be afraid." The world's peace depends on circumstances: health, money, stability. But Christ's peace stands firm in the storm, for it flows from His presence, not from circumstances.

How do we live this chapter? First: let not your heart be troubled. No matter how frightening the news or how hard the circumstances, remember that a place is prepared for you in the Father's house, and that Christ is coming to take you Himself. Second: hold to the only Way. In a world offering many roads to God, trust Christ's word: "no man cometh unto the Father, but by me." Do not be ashamed of this faith; witness to it in love. Third: seek His peace, not the world's peace. When your heart is troubled, do not run first to human solutions; kneel and pray, and you will find a peace that passes all understanding guarding your heart. Fourth: know the Father through the Son. Read the Gospels intending to see God's heart in every word and deed of Christ.

Finally, notice that Christ said all this knowing they would all flee within hours. He did not rebuke them for their coming weakness; He comforted them in advance. This is how He deals with you: He knows your coming falls before they happen, yet He loves you, prepares a place for you, and promises you His peace. His love does not depend on your perfection, but on His perfection. So let no feeling of unworthiness keep you away from Him; He knows you fully and still says to you: let not your heart be troubled.

Chapter 10

The Vine and the Branches (John 15)

The vine and the branches. Jesus used an image from His disciples' daily life: the vine. He said, "I am the true vine, and my Father is the husbandman. Every branch in me that beareth not fruit he taketh away: and every branch that beareth fruit, he purgeth it, that it may bring forth more fruit." Then He commanded them: "Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit of itself, except it abide in the vine; no more can ye, except ye abide in me."

This image reveals the whole secret of the Christian life: fruit is not produced by human effort, but by abiding in Christ. The branch does not toil or strive to bring forth grapes; its only task is to stay connected to the vine, and the sap flows through it automatically and it bears fruit. So it is with the believer: he does not produce love, joy, and peace by his own strength, but by abiding in Christ, and the Holy Spirit bears fruit in him spontaneously. Many weary themselves trying to be good by their own strength and fail; the secret is not greater effort, but deeper connection.

Then Christ speaks of pruning: "and every branch that beareth fruit, he purgeth it, that it may bring forth more fruit." The wise vinedresser cuts from the vine the excess shoots and the leaves that absorb nourishment uselessly — not to harm it, but to make it bear more fruit. This is how God deals with us: sometimes He allows hardships, or removes from our lives things we love — not from cruelty, but as pruning, so that our lives bear more fruit. So do not grumble when you are pruned; thank the wise Husbandman who knows what He is doing.

Christ explains how we abide in Him: "If ye abide in me, and my words abide in you, ye shall ask what ye will, and it shall be done unto you." Abiding in Christ means two things: a living, continuous relationship with Him in prayer and fellowship, and His word abiding in us — knowing the Scripture and obeying it. When these two are realized, our prayers are answered, because our will has become one with His will; we ask what He wants, and He gives generously.

Then He reveals the goal of it all: "Herein is my Father glorified, that ye bear much fruit; so shall ye be my disciples." God's glory is not in our being outwardly religious, but in our lives being fruitful: true love, effective service, souls won for the kingdom. And He seals it with the sweetest promise: "These things have I spoken unto you, that my joy might remain in you, and that your joy might be full." Full joy is not in comfortable circumstances, but in abiding in Christ and bearing fruit for Him. The fruitful branch is the joyful branch.

Nor must we forget His serious warning: "If a man abide not in me, he is cast forth as a branch, and is withered; and men gather them, and cast them into the fire, and they are burned." Separation from Christ results in spiritual dryness, then destruction. Christianity is not a membership card kept in the pocket, but a living, permanent connection. Whoever breaks off from prayer, God's word, and the fellowship of believers withers gradually, no matter how strong his beginning was.

How do we live this chapter? First: make abiding your daily priority. Before you busy yourself producing fruit, busy yourself with connection to the Source: begin your day with prayer and God's word, and stay connected to Christ through the day with short prayers of the heart. Second: accept pruning with thanks. When you pass through a hard circumstance, ask: What does the Husbandman want to prune in me? — instead of: Why is this happening to me? Third: judge your life by fruit, not by activity. You may be busy with many services yet without true fruit; examine yourself: Am I growing in love? Am I winning souls? Is my character changing? Fourth: hold to the promise — "ye shall ask what ye will, and it shall be done unto you." Pray in faith, abiding in Him and His word abiding in you, and wait for the answer with confidence.

One practical question remains: how do I know I am truly abiding in Christ? The marks are clear: a growing love for God and for people, the fruit of the Spirit appearing in your character, God's word finding its place in your day, and prayer becoming a need rather than a duty. And if you find yourself dry, the remedy is not self-flagellation, but returning to the Vine: confess your disconnection, return to daily fellowship, and the sap will flow through you anew. The Vine never rejects a branch that returns repentant.

The Holy Spirit, the Comforter (John 16)

The Holy Spirit, the Comforter. The disciples were sorrowful because Christ had told them He was going away from them. He said to them a strange word: "Nevertheless I tell you the truth; It is expedient for you that I go away: for if I go not away, the Comforter will not come unto you; but if I depart, I will send him unto you." How could Christ's departure be to their advantage? Because Christ in His body was limited to one place, while the Holy Spirit would dwell in every believer in every place and time. Instead of Christ with them, Christ would be in them by His Spirit!

And who is the Comforter? The word "Comforter" in Greek means one called to your side to support you: the advocate, guide, encourager, and friend. And Christ said "another Comforter" — another like Myself, of the same kind. So the Holy Spirit is not a mere force, but a living divine Person, working in us what Christ worked with the disciples: teaching, guiding, reminding, comforting.

Then Christ explained the Holy Spirit's work in the world: "And when he is come, he will reprove the world of sin, and of righteousness, and of judgment." Conviction is not harsh condemnation, but an awakening of conscience: it shows man his sin so he will repent, shows him Christ's righteousness so he will believe in Him, and shows him the coming judgment so he will prepare. Every true repentance in history began with the Holy Spirit's work in the heart. So when you feel the prick of conscience over a sin, do not flee from it; it is the Spirit's voice calling you to repentance and life.

His work in believers is greater still: "Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth." The Holy Spirit is our inner Teacher: He opens our minds to understand the Scriptures, guides us in our decisions, and reminds us of Christ's words in the hour of need. How many times have you read a verse many times, then suddenly it shone before you as if you were seeing it for the first time? That is the work of the Spirit of truth. So before you read the Bible, pray: "O Spirit of God, guide me into the truth."

Christ adds, "He shall glorify me: for he shall receive of mine, and shall shew it unto you." Notice that the Holy Spirit does not glorify Himself or draw attention to Himself, but always glorifies Christ. This is the mark distinguishing every true spiritual work: if it glorifies Christ and leads people to Him, it is of the Holy Spirit; if it glorifies a man or a group, or distracts from Christ, it is not of Him.

Then He comforted them concerning sorrow: "Verily, verily, I say unto you, That ye shall weep and lament, but the world shall rejoice: and ye shall be sorrowful, but your sorrow shall be turned into joy." He likened them to a woman in travail: she suffers for hours, then forgets the pain for the joy of the child. So our present pains — persecution, sickness, loss — will turn into eternal joy when we see Christ face to face. And the joy Christ gives, "your joy no man taketh from you," for it flows from within, not from circumstances.

How do we live this chapter? First: welcome the Holy Spirit into your life. He is not a distant guest, but dwells in you since your baptism and chrismation. Speak with Him, and seek His guidance in every great and small decision. Second: respond to conviction quickly. When your conscience reproves you, do not justify or delay; confess and repent at once, for delay hardens the heart. Third: rely on Him to understand the Bible. Do not read the Gospel as an ordinary book; pray before reading that the Spirit would open your eyes, and you will be amazed at the new depths. Fourth: test every teaching by its fruit: does it glorify Christ? That is the measure. Fifth: in your sorrow remember the promise: your sorrow shall be turned into joy, and the joy Christ gives, no one can take from you.

Finally, remember that the Holy Spirit has dwelt in you since the holy mystery of chrismation, and He never leaves you. You may grieve Him with your sin so that His work grows dim, but He does not abandon you. So when you feel far from God, do not search for Him far away; return within yourself, repent, and you will find Him there waiting for you. As one of the Fathers said: God is nearer to you than yourself. Live, then, every day in awareness of His indwelling presence, and your ordinary life will become a living temple glorifying God.

Chapter 12

The Intercessory Prayer (John 17)

The intercessory prayer. After Jesus finished His discourse with His disciples, He "lifted up his eyes to heaven" and prayed. This prayer — the whole seventeenth chapter — is the holiest prayer in the Bible, for it is the Son's prayer to the Father hours before the cross. In it we hear Christ's own heart: What does He ask? For whom does He pray? And the answer fills the heart with joy: He prayed for you!

The prayer falls into three parts: first He prayed for Himself: "Father, the hour is come; glorify thy Son, that thy Son also may glorify thee." The hour of which He had so often said it had not yet come — the hour of the cross — has come at last. And Christ seeks glory not for Himself, but to accomplish the work of salvation and glorify the Father. Then He gives a wonderful definition of eternal life: "And this is life eternal, that they might know thee the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent." Eternal life is not a long stretch of time, but a living, personal knowledge of God. It begins now, in this moment, the more you know God.

Second, He prayed for His disciples: "I pray for them: I pray not for the world, but for them which thou hast given me; for they are thine." What did He ask for them? He asked the Father to keep them from the evil one, to sanctify them in the truth — to set them apart and purify them by His word — and to keep them in the unity of love. Notice He did not ask to take them out of the world, but to keep them in the world. We are called to live in the world without being of it: light in the darkness, salt preserving from corruption — neither isolated in monasteries of the heart nor dissolved in the world's current.

Third — and here is the joyful surprise — He prayed for us: "Neither pray I for these alone, but for them also which shall believe on me through their word." Yes — two thousand years ago, with Christ on His way to the cross, He mentioned you by name before the Father! You were in His heart as He prayed. So never say you are forgotten or unimportant; Christ prayed for you personally.

And what did He ask for us? He asked for unity: "That they all may be one; as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us." The unity of believers is not a luxury or an idealistic dream, but Christ's last command and a testimony to the world: "that the world may believe that thou hast sent me." When the world sees Christians loving and united despite their differences, it believes Christ is from God. When it sees divisions and quarrels, it stumbles. Our unity is not for our comfort, but for the world's salvation.

He also asked that we be with Him in His glory: "Father, I will that they also, whom thou hast given me, be with me where I am; that they may behold my glory." Christ wants us with Him! Not a cold salvation from afar, but an intimate, eternal fellowship. He sealed the prayer: "And I have declared unto them thy name, and will declare it: that the love wherewith thou hast loved me may be in them, and I in them." The goal of everything is that the Father's love would dwell in our hearts, and Christ would dwell in us.

How do we live this chapter? First: rejoice and be assured — Christ prayed for you, and He still intercedes for you now at the Father's right hand. You are carried on a prayer that never fails. Second: know God more every day, for this is eternal life. Do not settle for knowing information about Him; build a living relationship with Him through prayer and the word. Third: be one with your brothers and sisters. Forgive whoever wronged you, seek peace with those you differed with, and reject the spirit of division and partisanship in church and home. Remember: your unity is a testimony to the world. Fourth: live in the world without being of it. Be a light in your work and school, and do not be ashamed of your holiness; the world needs your salt and your light.

Reflect on His words: "Sanctify them through thy truth: thy word is truth." Sanctification — being set apart for God and purified from evil — comes through the word. The more you cling to God's word in reading, memorizing, and obeying, the more your life is sanctified spontaneously. The Bible is not information for the mind, but a purifier of the heart. Keep a daily appointment with the word, and within weeks you will see the difference in your thoughts, your speech, and your decisions.

Chapter 13

The Trial and the Crucifixion (John 18-19)

The trial and the crucifixion. After the prayer in Gethsemane, Judas came with soldiers and servants of the chief priests, with lanterns, torches, and weapons, to arrest Jesus. When Jesus asked them, "Whom seek ye?" they answered, "Jesus of Nazareth." He said to them, "I am he." And "as soon then as he had said unto them, I am he, they went backward, and fell to the ground!" Even in the moment of His arrest, He displayed His divine authority: a single word from Him felled the cohort. He was not seized because He was weak, but because He surrendered Himself willingly at the appointed time.

Jesus was led first to Annas, then to Caiaphas the high priest, where they held a sham nighttime trial full of irregularities. Outside, Peter was warming himself by the fire, and he denied his Master three times, as Christ had foretold; and when the cock crew, he remembered the Lord's word and went out and wept bitterly. O the weakness of man! Hours earlier he had said, "Lord, why cannot I follow thee now? I will lay down my life for thy sake." But Christ knew his weakness and loved him still — and we shall see how He restored him in the final chapter.

In the morning they took Him to Pontius Pilate, the Roman governor, for they had no authority to execute. Pilate examined the case and found Jesus innocent, declaring it three times: "I find in him no fault at all." He tried to release Him after the scourging, but the crowds cried, "Crucify him, crucify him!" And when Pilate said to them, "Shall I crucify your King?" the chief priests gave the dreadful answer: "We have no king but Caesar!" — they denied God's kingdom for the sake of politics.

The most famous dialogue of the trial was about the kingdom: Pilate asked, "Art thou the King of the Jews?" Jesus answered, "My kingdom is not of this world: if my kingdom were of this world, then would my servants fight, that I should not be delivered to the Jews: but now is my kingdom not from hence." Then Pilate asked, "Art thou a king then?" He answered, "Thou sayest that I am a king. To this end was I born, and for this cause came I into the world,

that I should bear witness unto the truth. Every one that is of the truth heareth my voice." Pilate spoke his famous word with scorn: "What is truth?" — and went out without waiting for the answer. And the Truth was standing before him! How many people today ask about the truth and do not wait for the answer!

Jesus went forth to Golgotha bearing His cross. There He was crucified between two thieves, and above His head a title in three languages: "JESUS OF NAZARETH THE KING OF THE JEWS." From the cross He cared for His mother, and when He thirsted He was given vinegar; and at the end He cried the immortal word: "It is finished!" Then "he bowed his head, and gave up the ghost." His life was not taken from Him; He laid it down willingly after completing all things: the prophecies were fulfilled, salvation accomplished, the price paid in full.

John — the only eyewitness among the apostles — records a detail no one else mentioned: when the soldiers came to break the legs of the crucified, they found Jesus already dead and did not break His legs; "but one of the soldiers with a spear pierced his side, and forthwith came there out blood and water." And John testifies, "And he that saw it bare record, and his record is true." The Church sees in the blood and water flowing from Christ's side the mysteries of baptism and the Eucharist: from Christ's pierced side the Church was born, as Eve was taken from Adam's side. Then the body was taken down and laid in a new tomb in a nearby garden.

How do we live this chapter? First: contemplate that Christ suffered willingly for you. He was not forced to the cross; He chose it out of love for you. When you doubt His love, look at the cross. Second: beware Peter's weakness in you — overconfidence before the fall. Do not say "I will never fall," but "Lord, keep me." Third: do not be like Pilate, who knew the truth and surrendered it for fear of men. When you know the truth, stand with it whatever the cost. Fourth: live by the power of "It is finished": your salvation was fully accomplished on the cross; do not try to add to it by your own merit, but receive it by faith and live thankfully.

The Resurrection and the Appearances (John 20)

The resurrection and the appearances. At dawn on Sunday, while it was still dark, Mary Magdalene came to the tomb and found the stone taken away from the tomb! She ran to Peter and John and said, "They have taken away the Lord out of the sepulchre, and we know not where they have laid him!" The two disciples ran to the tomb. John entered, saw the linen clothes lying and the napkin wrapped together in a place by itself — "and he saw, and believed." Note the eyewitness's precision: had anyone stolen the body, they would not have left the graveclothes arranged like this. The resurrection happened quietly and majestically, with no human witnesses — for it is God's pure work.

But Mary Magdalene stayed standing outside the tomb weeping. As she stooped to look into the tomb, she saw two angels; then she turned and saw Jesus standing, and did not know it was Jesus! She supposed Him to be the gardener, and said to Him, "Sir, if thou have borne him hence, tell me where thou hast laid him, and I will take him away." Jesus said to her one word that changed everything: "Mary." He called her by name, and she knew Him at once and cried, "Rabboni!" — that is, Teacher. The risen Christ knows each one of us by name, and when He calls us we know Him. Then He sent her with a message to His brethren: "Go to my brethren, and say unto them, I ascend unto my Father, and your Father; and to my God, and your God." Notice the tenderness: after the resurrection He no longer calls them servants or disciples, but "my brethren"! And Mary Magdalene — out of whom had gone seven demons — became the first preacher of the resurrection, "the apostle to the apostles" as the Church calls her.

That same evening, Jesus appeared to the disciples with the doors shut for fear of the Jews, and said to them, "Peace be unto you!" Then He showed them His hands and His side, and the disciples were glad when they saw the Lord. Then He breathed on them and said, "Receive ye the Holy Ghost." Eight days later He appeared again for Thomas, who had not been with them, and said to him, "Reach hither thy finger, and behold my hands; and reach hither thy hand, and

thrust it into my side: and be not faithless, but believing." Thomas cried out the greatest confession of faith in the whole Gospel: "My Lord and my God!" Christ did not rebuke him for this confession, but accepted it — for it is true. Jesus is Lord and God. Then He said to him, "Thomas, because thou hast seen me, thou hast believed: blessed are they that have not seen, and yet have believed." This beatitude is for us, who believe after two thousand years without seeing with our eyes!

Then John closes the chapter with the purpose of all he wrote: "And many other signs truly did Jesus in the presence of his disciples, which are not written in this book: But these are written, that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God; and that believing ye might have life through his name." Jesus did far more signs than were recorded, but John chose what suffices for faith. The Gospel is not a history encyclopedia, but an invitation: believe, and you shall have life.

How do we live this chapter? First: rejoice in the resurrection every day, not only on Easter. Christ's resurrection means death is defeated, you have eternal life, and nothing is impossible with God. Begin your day with the heart's shout: Christ is risen! Second: learn from the Magdalene — seek Christ with your tears as she sought Him, and you will hear Him call you by name. Third: like Thomas, do not be ashamed of your doubts; bring them to Christ honestly, and He will meet you as He met Thomas. But do not remain in doubt; cross over to confession: "My Lord and my God." Fourth: receive the beatitude — you are among those who believed without seeing, and this is a special beatitude from Christ's own mouth. Your faith is more precious to Him than you think.

Finally, reflect on Christ's word to Mary: "Touch me not; for I am not yet ascended to my Father." He was not barring her from joy, but lifting her gaze from passing emotional joy to the eternal truth: relationship with the risen Christ is deeper than physical touch; it is an unbroken spiritual fellowship. Today we do not touch Him with our hands, but we are united with Him in the mystery of the Eucharist, and we dwell in Him by the Holy Spirit. And that is far greater than a fleeting touch on the shore of the empty tomb.

By the Sea of Tiberias: Do You Love Me? (John 21)

By the Sea of Tiberias: do you love me? After the resurrection, Peter and some of the disciples returned to Galilee, and one night Peter said, "I go a fishing." They went with him, and that night they caught nothing. Why did they return to fishing? Perhaps because Peter — after denying Christ — felt he was no longer fit for service, and went back to his old trade. How many of us, after a fall, return to our old life thinking God is done with us!

In the morning, Jesus stood on the shore, but they did not know it was Jesus, and He said to them, "Children, have ye any meat?" They answered, "No." He said, "Cast the net on the right side of the ship, and ye shall find." They cast, and now they were not able to draw it for the multitude of fishes! Then John said to Peter, "It is the Lord!" When Peter heard it was the Lord, he girded his fisher's coat about him and threw himself into the sea to swim to the shore — he could not wait for the boat to arrive! True love cannot bear delay.

On the shore they found a fire of coals, with fish laid on it, and bread — Christ had prepared breakfast for them Himself! O His tenderness: the God of the universe grilling fish for His hungry disciples. Then, after they had dined, came the decisive moment: Jesus turned to Simon Peter and said, "Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou me more than these?" He asked him three times — the number of his three denials! And each time Peter answered, "Yea, Lord; thou knowest that I love thee." And each time Christ commissioned him: "Feed my lambs... Feed my sheep."

Notice Christ's wonderful wisdom in restoring Peter: He did not rebuke him for the denial, did not remind him of his fall, and did not impose a harsh test. He asked him only about love: "Lovest thou me?" — for love is everything. Whoever truly loves Christ will serve Him faithfully. Notice also that Christ did not ask him: Are you sorry? Have you learned the lesson? Are you competent? He asked him about his heart. And service, in Christ's eyes, is not qualifications or abilities, but love. Then He restored the commission: "Feed my sheep." The repentant fallen one is not cast aside, but restored to service

with greater honor.

Then Christ foretold the kind of death by which Peter would glorify God — the cross — and said to him, "Follow me." When Peter turned and saw John and asked, "Lord, and what shall this man do?" Jesus answered him, "If I will that he tarry till I come, what is that to thee? follow thou me!" A lesson for us all: do not compare yourself with others or busy yourself with their plan; you have your own calling: "follow thou me."

And John closes his whole Gospel with this testimony: "This is the disciple which testifieth of these things, and wrote these things: and we know that his testimony is true. And there are also many other things which Jesus did, the which, if they should be written every one, I suppose that even the world itself could not contain the books that should be written." What a magnificent ending! Jesus is greater than books can contain; but what is written suffices for us to believe and to live.

How do we live this chapter? First: do not go back to your old nets after a fall. No matter how far you fell, Christ stands on the shore of your life waiting for you; He is not done with you. Return to Him now. Second: answer the most important question every day: "Lovest thou me?" Before you ask about service, success, or the future, examine your love. Everything else flows from love. Third: accept restoration. If you feel your past sin has disqualified you from serving God, hear His voice saying to you as He said to Peter: "Feed my sheep." Sincere repentance wipes the past completely. Fourth: follow Christ yourself, and do not compare your path with another's. His plan for you is unique, and His will for your life is good and perfect.

In closing, notice that after restoring Peter, Christ did not say to him: sit and rest. He sent him into service at once: feed my sheep. True repentance does not end with weeping over the past, but begins with working for the future. Whatever your past, God has a plan for you today. Rise, follow Christ, and serve His sheep — in your home, in your church, wherever He places you. For the love that forgave you deserves to be served with all your heart.

Conclusion

We have now completed the journey through the Gospel of John, from "In the beginning was the Word" to "follow thou me." We have seen Christ declare Himself: the eternal Word, the Bread of Life, the Light of the World, the Good Shepherd, the Resurrection and the Life, the Way, the Truth, and the Life, the True Vine. And we have seen Him love: the fearful Nicodemus, the outcast Samaritan woman, the condemned woman, the dead Lazarus, the fallen Peter, the doubting Thomas. In every story the question was one: do you believe?

John wrote his Gospel for one purpose, which he declared plainly: "that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God; and that believing ye might have life through his name." So the question is now addressed to you personally: do you believe? Not a theoretical faith of the mind only, but the faith of the heart that receives Christ as Lord and Savior, abides in Him as the branch in the vine, and loves Him above all.

If you have believed before, let this book be a new beginning: a deeper love, a stronger abiding, a bolder witness. And if you are still hesitant like Nicodemus or doubting like Thomas, come to Christ as you are; He will not turn you away. Tell Him simply today: "Lord, I believe; help thou mine unbelief."

And always remember His last words to Peter — they are for you too: "follow thou me." You are not required to understand everything, but to follow Him every day: in your prayer, in your home, in your work, in your love for people. And He who promised, "I am with you always" — go then on the way: the Word who became flesh walks with you, the comforting Spirit guides you, and the Father awaits you in the house of many mansions. Amen.

Finally, do not let this book be closed and forgotten on a shelf. Keep it beside your Bible, and return to it whenever you read the Gospel of John anew, for you will discover new depths in it every time. And share what you have learned with others: tell your family, your friends, or your church Bible-study group. For the Word that changed your life is able to change the lives of others too. And the grace that began with you is not complete until it overflows to those around you.